Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Jimmy Witherspoon

Blues and jazz vocalist Jimmy Witherspoon was born in 1923 and grew up surrounded by Baptist choir music and the blues played by local Arkansas musicians. His musical debut came in the unlikely city of Calcutta during his service in the Merchant Marine. On his return to California, he met Jay McShann and replaced Walter Brown as Jay's vocalist. A list of hits followed, including "Ain't Nobody's Business" and "Big Fine Girl." Jimmy has recorded steadily throughout his career and counts his triumph at the 1959 Monterey Jazz Festival and his service during World War II as highlights in his life. He can often be found in the company of early bandmates Jay McShann and Claude "Fiddler" Williams.

Jimmy was interviewed by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive, at the Sarasota Jazz Festival on April 12, 1996.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. My name is Monk Rowe and it's a great pleasure to have with me Mr. Jimmy Witherspoon, in Sarasota, Florida. He had a long trip out to the East Coast I would imagine.

JW: Yeah, from California.

MR: Well I'm glad you're here, and I just want to spend a few minutes talking about your career and did you have some church influence when you grew up?

JW: Yeah. You know I did.

MR: Singing in the Baptist church?

JW: Still do.

MR: Yeah.

JW: Yeah, I still sing in church occasionally.

MR: And did I read that you were in the Merchant Marine?

JW: I was in the Merchant Marine in World War II.

MR: When you were growing up, was it mostly the radio that you heard at home?

JW: Well I had no television then. When I grew up — I must divulge my age, now I'm 73. So you know when I was a kid there was no television.

MR: What kind of music was going on in your home?

JW: Jimmy Lunceford, Count Basie, Benny Goodman, Artie Shaw, Andy Kirk, Jay McShann. Those kind of people you know.

MR: Some of those people who you later on in life became pretty familiar with.

JW: Duke Ellington, naturally.

MR: Now from what I've read you had an interesting first experience in performing music halfway around the world?

JW: What do you mean?

MR: Didn't you sing with a group in Calcutta?

JW: Calcutta.

MR: Yeah? Can you tell me about that? How did that come about?

JW: I was in the service. I just walked up and sang that's all. And that was it.

MR: Had he been there for a while?

JW: Yes he had. Teddy had been there in China with Buck Clayton, Carlton Roberts and that bunch.

MR: That's right, Buck Clayton was one of the first fellows to go over in that part of the world?

JW: Yeah. So he stayed. And the rest of them came back.

MR: Did you have aspirations at that time, when you were in the Merchant Marine, to be a singer?

JW: I was trying to sing like the Ink Spots then. But that night I sang like Wynonie Harris. blues.

MR: They must have liked you, huh?

JW: They did.

MR: And how long were you in the Merchant Marine until?

JW: I was there about three — two or three years. I'm a veteran now. They did give us veteran status.

MR: They did, that's right, not that long ago.

JW: Well actually we were in the war before America declared war. We were, they was keeping it quiet, but we were actually making the Murmansk run for the Ammunition Department, by way of, via Calcutta. And the public, America didn't know it. Nobody knew it.

MR: The war effort was already underway.

JW: The war effort. We were taking ammunition to England, see but on the paper it just said England was fighting. But it wasn't.

MR: But you were in danger because of the submarines and all that?

JW: Oh, they was taking it. So they finally changed, the Congress pulled us, and we were under the Coast Guard anyway, during that time. So they made us veterans.

MR: Did you sign, when you signed in to the Merchant Marine, you sign for a certain amount of time?

JW: Right.

MR: You don't just say I'm tired of this, I want to go.

JW: Well during that time you couldn't do that. If you did that, like I say we were more or less in the war. Because we couldn't just get out there.

MR: Well that's really interesting. And when you got out of the service, you came back to, did you end up in Kansas City or did you —

JW: Vallejo.

MR: Vallejo, California?

JW: Then that's where I joined Jay McShann. Actually, that's where the mess started.

MR: Would you do it again? Who did you replace, or did he have a singer before you?

JW: Walter Brown, and he had some other singer for a little while. But really it was Walter Brown.

MR: He had had a few records that were fairly well known, right?

JW: Hit records.

MR: Yeah.

JW: "Stomping the Blues."

MR: But it wasn't long before you had your own.

JW: That's right.

MR: That's right and —

JW: With Jay McShann playing piano. He came and did that for me. I just got through having breakfast with him.

MR: Should be an interesting concert tonight. I can't wait. What was the work like at that time? Were you playing dances? Little clubs?

JW: Dances and big clubs, big ballrooms.

MR: Was the audience at that time segregated.

JW: Sure it was segregated. We had to go in the back of restaurants. I remember a time in Miami, I could go to a club on the beach where the Jewish people couldn't go.

MR: That's strange. And this is in the 50s?

JW: No, this is in the '40s. This was bad. This was bad. I could go to the beach because I was an entertainer. I could go in the club, but the Jews couldn't come in. People talk about prejudice, racism and all that, it's always been and it always will be.

MR: Has the music helped to make it any better?

JW: No. No. What has happened is, you have some wonderful people in music, like Bonnie Raitt, Van Morrison, real, but you've got a lot of phonies in the music business, who could help bridge that gap. Like the Rolling Stones, who couldn't keep a beat if you give them twenty drums. Mick Jagger could learn a lot by putting a black artist on some of his concerts. Do you hear what I'm saying? He's stolen so much from us. I'm not bitter but I am aware of what they've done, and it hurts sometimes. But Van Morrison just called me the other day. He's called me three times and a couple of times just to say hello. The last time he called, it was four days ago, asking would I play with him in New York for four

days this month. Now we are so tight that there was no money discussed. You know why? Because he's going to pay me what I'm worth.

MR: A gentleman's agreement.

JW: Sure. You see it's stuff we don't discuss. He knows what I'm worth.

MR: I'm glad to hear that.

JW: Yes.

MR: When is that going to happen?

JW: It's going to happen the 26, 27, 28 and 29th of this month.

MR: In a club?

JW: Yes it's in a club. I forget what's the name of it. It's all sold out.

MR: That's exciting. Yeah. That's great. When you first started recording with Jay McShann, what was a record session like compared to these days. Did you go in and kind of do the whole album and —

JW: We'd do the whole album in about six hours. Three hours one day, three hours the next day. That's it. Probably two microphones.

MR: One for you and one for the band.

JW: One for the band. And one for Jay. About three.

MR: It worked, didn't it.

JW: And with Count Basie, and do you know what? Two tracks still. It's the best form of recording. Two tracks. Of course you've got everybody there.

MR: And they're listening to each other.

JW: They are listening to each other.

MR: We just got through watching some old Basie movies. You could hear everything, even the bass, you could hear everything. You could hear the singing. Now didn't you travel to Japan with Basie?

JW: Yup. How'd you know that?

MR: I've been doing some reading. What was that like?

JW: Wonderful. Being with Basie man, was, I wish I could have afforded to stay in that band. He and I talked and financially, he couldn't pay me what I wanted. But that was like being the Vice President of the United States. Benny Powell, what a great man. I was in the big, the best band.

MR: With Benny—

JW: Frank Wess, Frank Foster, you name 'em. Marshall Royal, Ernie Royal.

MR: Who was in the rhythm section at that time? Sonny Payne maybe?

JW: Sonny Payne, Buddy Catlett. Buddy Catlett is in that new movie I just did, "Georgia." That's him playing bass.

MR: All right. Can't wait to see that.

JW: With Jennifer Jason Lee.

MR: It must have felt pretty good to stand in front of that group. And what was the audience reaction like in Japan?

JW: Great.

MR: Tell me about your hits you had with Jay McShann. Were these songs that —

JW: I didn't have no hits that he recorded with me. "Ain't Nobody's Business," that was a big one.

MR: Yeah. It's right on here. Will you sign that for us before you leave?

JW: I sure will.

MR: You did that song in forty—

JW: '49.

MR: '49. And did it get a lot of airplay at that time?

JW: Yes. See I can't understand the system. During that time there was mostly white disc jockeys, but they had black shows. You had Nashville, in Tennessee, why you could get all over America. But it was white disc jockeys, you had, Atlanta, Georgia, white disc jockeys were the top jockeys. You have white jockeys today who won't play black music, I mean black blues. It's kind of funny, isn't it?

MR: It's funny and it's still going on because tonight, your audience, you know—

JW: Will be white.

MR: Will be white.

JW: I know it will.

MR: And they love the music.

JW: They know what it is.

MR: They know what it is and I can't understand it either.

JW: The man who ran this record shop used to be from Nashville, Tennessee. Nothing but rhythm & blues.

MR: Well that's the foundation for rock & roll, too.

JW: I know it. What's his name was in Cleveland.

MR: Alan Freed?

JW: Alan Freed. Chess set him up. So you had Hunter Hancock was in Los Angeles. So you had big white disc jockeys. And I mean they were selling records.

MR: And then you had Sam Phillips, making recordings in Memphis.

JW: That's right.

MR: And recording some great black artists, but he didn't really make his money until he found Elvis, who was singing black music.

JW: Black music. As a matter of fact I was recording with RCA Victor that week that, I'm trying to think of his name, went down, the sign presser—

MR: From RCA.

JW: From RCA.

MR: Yeah I can't recall his name either.

JW: Anyway, he came back, we was in the studio. And he said, "Man I just signed — God I know they're going to fire me, because we gave him so much money," and that's who it was. I'm trying to think of his name. RCA Victor has still got those tapes that I did with —

MR: It wasn't his manager you're talking about.

JW: Um mmm.

MR: This was an RCA man.

JW: It was an RCA man.

MR: Well, I guess he didn't get fired.

JW: No he didn't.

MR: My. So, what was it like, I don't know if you can describe what it's like being on the road, in the late '40s and early '50s?

JW: Oh it was fun. It was a lot of fun.

MR: You traveled mostly by bus? Or car?

JW: Car.

MR: Because you had a fairly small group at that time.

JW: A station wagon.

MR: Did you have agents that set up your work for you?

JW: Yeah. It was a lot of fun. But it's more fun now.

MR: Accommodations a little better most of the time? And you get to fly I guess. What since the, oh, tell me about the Monterey Jazz Festival, which seems to have been a nice point in your career.

JW: My mother was there.

MR: Your mother was there.

JW: It was the first time she'd ever heard me sing the blues in person.

MR: You're kidding.

JW: She is a very religious woman and she wouldn't go to no, you know, no night clubs. And a delight for me.

MR: So there you are at the Monterey Jazz Festival with some pretty good sidemen.

JW: You know the funny thing about that night, the audience didn't know I was there. They found me in Newport, Kentucky. So I wasn't even on the bill. And everybody was leaving, and Jimmy Lyon said, "Hold it, hold it, we're not through." And they called me in, and I was with some insignificant musicians by the name of Ben Webster, who else

was there, Bobby Brookmeyer, Roy Eldridge, Woody Herman, Coleman Hawkins, Earl Hines. What can you say?

MR: You broke it up, right?

JW: Yes we did.

MR: That's fantastic. What's in the future for you? You've got Van Morrison coming up.

JW: I'm going to England on the 5th of next month. I'm going to London for two dates.

MR: When you go overseas, do you take musicians with you?

JW: No.

MR: You work with a band over there?

JW: In fact it's singing to the beat. No, it's hard sometimes, but I get along.

MR: People, maybe their concept is a little bit different?

JW: Well they play good jazz.

MR: Yeah.

JW: And play blues you know.

MR: What kind of occasions have you had to be on stage with other singers, some of the other singers you've worked with.

JW: Everybody.

MR: Everybody.

JW: B.B. King, Bobby Blue Bland, Albert King. I just heard a record the other day by Freddie King, the late Freddie King. I didn't even know he cut "Ain't Nobody's Business."

MR: Oh, no kidding.

JW: I didn't realize it.

MR: Have you ever sung with Joe Williams on the same stage?

JW: Yes I have.

MR: You look forward to seeing Joe?

JW: Yes. Give him my regards.

MR: I certainly will. And tonight you do a set with Jay and —

JW: "The Fiddler."

MR: "The Fiddler." Plas Johnson.

JW: Yeah. I don't even know who's going to be on.

MR: Well we'll find out. I guess that's the beauty of this music is as long as you have capable musicians you can get together and—

JW: You don't have no problem.

MR: That's great.

JW: That's why I always rehearse, and it's stupid. It's hard, these musicians who know what they're doing, they've been doing it for fifty years, and you want to call a rehearsal, a sound check. Those are for the children. Those are for rock & rollers. I'm serious. Jazz,

in other words, they make a sound check, by the time the musicians start, we work hundreds of years to see how to project our voice, and here's a guy turning knobs. You understand what I mean?

MR: Doing it for you.

JW: Doing it for you and he can't do it. Not for jazz. It's not going to sound the same. So it's really stupid really.

MR: Yeah, times change and not always for the better as far as that goes I guess.

JW: And everybody loves, if there's a sound check man, they love to turn those damn knobs, and they don't know what the hell they're doing. I think they wanted to be musicians.

MR: I think so too.

JW: They couldn't play saxophone so they turn knobs.

MR: And they call it a gig.

JW: A gig, oh, what time is the sound check, and they will wait for months to do them sound checks.

MR: Oh, my. Well this has really been fascinating. You tired yet, because we can keep talking if you want.

JW: No, I'm tired.

MR: We are so glad you were able to join us, and I want to wish you the best of luck with Van Morrison. I hope he's up to playing next to you.

JW: Are you kidding? He's always — you know I'll tell you something about him. We were riding in a car in Chicago, and I said, "Listen, I'm not kissing your behind, but I want to tell you something, you remind me of Duke Ellington." He said, "In what way?" I says, "If you need a musician, a horn, saxophone, whatever, for two bars, that's all you want them for." He said, "You're right." I said, "That's the way Duke was." Whether you could read or not didn't make a difference. If you could do what he wanted on that tune, that's all he was interested in. And Morrison is the same way. Van Morrison.

MR: They know how to pick the right people.

JW: They know how to pick, yeah. They take their music serious.

MR: As you do I'm sure.

JW: I do. It's a personal thing with me.

MR: Right, okay. Well thanks so much on behalf of Hamilton College.

JW: Thank you, Monk.

MR: It's been a real pleasure.

JW: What a great name.

MR: It does me all right.

JW: He was a big fan of mine, well we were fans of each other. And when I played and I used to play at the Trident, in Sausalito, he and his wife would come over. As a matter of fact

he's invited me to his house, I've been to, when he was in the penthouse, I remember I walked in one night and he put on some old tunes. I said "Monk, is that you?" He says, "Boy, I'm a kid."

MR: He did such good things with the blues too you know.

JW: He stole so much from Jay McShann. "Blue Monk," that's Jay McShann. [scats] That's Jay McShann. I told him, he said, "Well, so?" You know.

MR: You steal from the best. Great. Okay, well we'll send you on your way and get you to your rehearsal which I know you're looking forward to. They said it would be a short one, so we're hoping it is.

JW: You can bet it's going to be a short one. I don't have no music. I left my music at the hotel. I don't need it.

MR: Don't need it. So it's going to be a short one. Well rehearse on the gig, that's what Miles used to say, right?

JW: I want Braille. I want Braille blues.

MR: All right, well thanks so much.

JW: Thank you.